

showed up for his Janata Darshans. "He is probably the most active chief minister in recent times. The party will reap benefits from his good public image if we go to polls now," says the chief minister's cabinet colleague Iqbal Ansari.

Speculation has been gaining ground especially after last fortnight when Gowda spent an hour with Governor Rameshwar Thakur that he has some plan up his sleeve. Many feel that the meeting was more than a courtesy call as has been claimed. He has told JD(s) workers that he is keen to maintain the "secular" image of the

be that easy as though a majority of the 58 JD(s) legislators are rallying behind Kumaraswamy and want him to continue in power, the party is actually weak in numbers. It will have to bank on the support of 13 independents and those who extend cross support to other parties while retaining the affiliation of the party from which they are elected in order to overcome anti-defection provisions if it were to sever ties with the saffron party. JD(s) has support from three of five JD(U) legislators and is hoping to attract a big flock from BJP.

The Congress has 64 seats and

prepared for a mid-term poll.

If Gowda does not succeed in persuading the BJP high command to allow his son's continuance in power, he will taunt the Congress by threatening to pull out from the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) and align with the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance as a quid pro quo for allowing Kumaraswamy to remain in power. Gowda is scheduled to meet the top BJP leaders in Delhi later this week to talk on these lines. NDA needs good partners in the south especially after being ditched by Chandrababu Naidu's TDP and Jayalalithaa's AIADMK.

Another possible scenario could be that Kumaraswamy, on astrologers' advice, resigns from his post ahead of October 3 and recommends dissolution of the assembly under engineered circumstances. It will automatically mean disqualification of the Kumaraswamy group of 40 JD(s) MPs who have been, in any case, suspended by the party for having truck with BJP. The governor, in this case, will ask Kumaraswamy to be the caretaker chief minister for six months before the state goes for polls. This will give the party a breather to counter any sympathy factor that would accrue to BJP, especially the backlash

from the state's biggest caste group the Lingayats, who may be disappointed in not having their man Yediyurappa elevated to the top post.

Meanwhile, the chief minister is still in a state of confusion even though on August 31, speaking at a public rally in Tiptur taluk, about 70 km east of Bangalore, he had claimed that he was destined to continue as chief minister even after October 3. The chief minister is also a film producer and exhibitor of many Kannada movies but when it comes to scripting a political thriller, he cannot find anyone better than his own crafty politician father, Gowda, who is clearly calling the shots now.



party and having a truck with BJP will only harm its image in the long run. And Patel's appointment was just a symbolic expression of his long-term game plan. JD(s) legislators are also expected to oppose the handing over of power to BJP especially after suspected Hindu fanatics attacked Tamil Nadu chief minister M. Karunanidhi's daughter Tamizh Selvi's house in Bangalore on September 18 and torched a Tamil Nadu state bus in protest against his adverse remarks on Lord Ram. Gowda, however, is worried over the fact that these attacks took place right under the nose of a secular chief minister.

The estrangement with BJP may not

UNUSUAL POWER: Kumaraswamy is helpless before Gowda (above) one of the groups, led by Opposition leader Dharam Singh, does not mind an encore with JD(s). It was only last year that Kumaraswamy had pulled the plug on Singh's government. Gowda is fond of this eight-time legislator from Jewargi, who had kept his arch rival D.K. Shivakumar from the Cabinet during his tenure. "We are ready for any eventuality," says Singh, "but the party high command will take the final decision." But Shivakumar, who claims he has nearly 30 Congress legislators with him, says there should be no pact with JD(s) and the party should be